7 QUESTIONS TO ASK BEFORE YOU INVEST

The Corporate English Training Audit

A practical guide for HR leaders, Learning & Development managers, and executives evaluating English training programs.

1. Is the program built for your team, or is it generic?
2. How does the program measure progress?
3. How long until we see results in real business situations?
4. What is the instruction format, and why does it matter?
5. Does the instructor understand business, not just language?
6. Does the program use real work, or simulated exercises?
7. What does success look like, and who is responsible?

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The illusion of progress

The usual pattern looks like success on paper. Employees complete their sessions, attendance is recorded, and the budget is approved again next year, because nobody measured anything that would say otherwise.

Meanwhile the manager sees no change in how those people perform in English. Communication stays unclear, decisions get delayed, client relationships take damage, and professional opportunities go to someone else.

> **Most corporate English programs do not fail because employees are not trying. They fail because the program was never designed to produce business results.**

What is actually at stake

For companies with international teams or global clients, English communication is not a soft skill. It is operational infrastructure. Unclear communication in an international team turns into slower decisions, then more errors, then more rework, and finally weaker client relationships.

The right investment shows visible results within months. The wrong one produces completed attendance records and nothing else. These seven questions tell the two apart before you sign.

QUESTION 1

Is the program built for your team, or is it generic?

"Business English" is a category, not a program.

A software engineer and a sales director both need "business English," and almost nothing else about their needs overlaps. The engineer has to write clear technical documentation, and failure there means system errors and delayed sprints. The director has to lead high-stakes client calls, and failure there means lost revenue and damaged trust.

Software engineer

Core task: clear technical documentation. Format: technical discussions and asynchronous text. Cost of failure: system errors, delayed sprints.

Sales director

Core task: high-stakes client calls. Format: live negotiation and persuasive presentation. Cost of failure: lost revenue, damaged trust.

> **ASK THE PROVIDER**
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> Ask: "How would you structure sessions differently for a developer versus a director?" If the provider gives the same answer for every role, the program is generic, and generic programs produce generic results.

QUESTION 2

How does the program measure progress?

Grammar test scores are not business outcomes.

The trap is a program that reports grammar test scores, which lets a provider sell sessions without ever committing to an outcome. The standard is a program that starts from a baseline assessment and measures execution quality until business risk visibly drops.

The trap

Grammar test scores. Sessions sold without outcomes.

The standard

Demonstrated business outcomes: baseline assessment, then execution quality, then reduced business risk.

ASK THE PROVIDER

Ask for outcomes stated as observable behavior: “This manager can lead a client call independently by week 8.” “This engineer can explain technical issues live without follow-up clarification.” “This director can present quarterly results without preparation anxiety.” Demonstrated capability in real situations is the measure.

QUESTION 3

How long until we see results in real business situations?

Realistic timelines come with a method attached.

Be cautious of programs that promise fast results without explaining how. Higher-level communication, such as executive presence and negotiation, takes two to four months of focused work.

Weeks 1–4

Cleaner communication, more confident meeting participation, fewer daily misunderstandings.

Weeks 5–8

More structured responses, less hesitation, greater control in discussions.

Weeks 8–12+

Leading conversations, handling pressure effectively, clarity that holds up.

ASK THE PROVIDER

Ask what changes by week 4, by week 8 and by week 12, and how each change will be observed. A provider who cannot name the stages has not planned them.

QUESTION 4

What is the instruction format, and why does it matter?

Format should follow the person, not the provider's scheduling.

Each format has a job. The mistake is a provider that only offers one of them.

Large group classes
Move at the pace of the group and cannot address individual weaknesses.

Small group (3–4 people)
Highly effective when peers share the same role, the same gaps, and the same goals.

One-on-one
The fastest path to improvement for high-priority roles.

> **ASK THE PROVIDER**
> Ask how they determine the format for each employee. A provider offering only one format is not personalizing the program. They are simplifying their own operations.

QUESTION 5

Does the instructor understand business, not just language?

Teaching skill and professional experience are two different qualifications.

A certified language teacher brings training in linguistics and teaching methods. Someone with professional experience knows the operational cost when a message is unclear at the wrong moment. A business communication coach has both: strong teaching skills and direct experience in professional contexts.

> **ASK THE PROVIDER**
> Ask about the instructor's background outside the classroom. Have they coached the specific type of professional your team needs?

QUESTION 6

Does the program use real work, or simulated exercises?

Practice has to happen on the job, not next to it.

Fictional business situations and generic exercises produce classroom improvement that does not transfer to the job at speed or in depth. Real emails from last week, the presentation currently in preparation, and specific client scenarios produce on-the-job improvement that transfers immediately.

Building sessions from the learner's actual work materials decides whether the training sits beside the job or connects directly to it.

ASK THE PROVIDER

Ask what material a typical session is built on. If the answer is a textbook unit rather than the participant's own documents and meetings, expect skills that stay in the classroom.

QUESTION 7

What does success look like, and who is responsible?

Results come from three parties, not one.

Success is shared. If any one of the three parties does not hold up its part, results stall regardless of the other two.

The learner
Practices consistently and applies corrections in real conversations.

The instructor
Diagnoses gaps and corrects in real time, under pressure.

The organization
Protects training time and aligns training with job demands.

ASK THE PROVIDER

Agree up front how success is measured on three dimensions: execution quality (clarity, structure, faster responses), risk reduction (fewer misunderstandings, faster decision cycles) and support reduction (less prompting, fewer corrections).

The true measure of progress: from dependency to autonomy

Progress is not a fixed level. It is a steady reduction in dependency. At the start, people need help finding words, need someone else to correct them, and need time to organize what they want to say. That gap between the support required and the capability available is operational business risk.

As training works, the support curve falls and autonomy rises: faster responses and independent handling of conversations.

BEFORE
"I think maybe the issue is… something with the system."

AFTER
"The issue is in the integration layer."

The final standard: efficiency vs. effectiveness

Warning signs of an efficiency-driven program

- “All levels welcome,” with no segmentation by role.
- No baseline assessment tied to real job demands.
- Price is the only differentiator.
- A fixed, generic curriculum for every student regardless of industry.

Signs of an outcome-driven program

- Content built around each person’s level, role and professional goals.
- Progress tracked by execution quality, not just language proficiency.
- Format and intensity that adjust as the learner develops.
- Performance measured under real business conditions.

You now have the right questions

Most organizations evaluate English training using the wrong criteria. If you want a direct, honest conversation about where communication is breaking down in your team, let's talk.

- Evaluate your team's communication gaps.
- Determine realistic, measurable outcomes.
- No sales presentation. No pressure to commit.

Book a 30-minute discovery call

www.nyenglishteacher.com/en/book/

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